

3RD NATIONAL CONGRESS IN LINZ



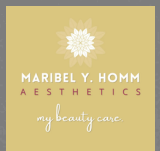
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JANET HEISS



BY: REXIL ORTEGA BORDAJE

EVENT THEME

Well-being and Belonging: Mental Health, Resilience, and Social Inclusion.

Addressing mental health, community support systems, and navigating dual identities in diaspora communities.

This event was organized in partnership with the **WKO (Wirtschaftskammer Oberösterreich)** and the **IFO (Internationale Fachkräfte-Offensive)**, the primary regional business representative in Upper Austria, headquartered in Linz. The initiative supports local companies in recruiting skilled workers from key non-EU countries to address workforce shortages. The event was further supported by SkillsHR, Wie Daham, YJYA, Vion, IVF Express, Maribel Homm Aesthetics, 24HelfendeHände, Simple Bookers, PinoyRelax, Infinity Balibayan Cargo, and Janet Heiss.

CORE OF SUCCESS!

The congress was proudly supported by the Philippine Embassy in Austria, a key institution serving and supporting Overseas Filipino Workers (OFWs) in the country. Opening greetings and a message of hope were delivered by **Ms. Candy Cypres-Bauzon**, First Secretary and Consul of the Philippine Embassy. Embassy programs and services were presented by **Atty. Delmer Cruz** and **Ms. Christelyn Caceres**.

Current issues and concerns affecting the Filipino community were discussed, and participants had the opportunity to raise questions and receive guidance. The Embassy also provided a service booth to facilitate OFW card processing and offer various consular and community services.



Mr. Andre Thorwartl of the WKO (Wirtschaftskammer Oberösterreich) and the IFO (Internationale Fachkräfte-Offensive) presented their services and advocacy initiatives aimed at supporting member companies in addressing workforce shortages. Key topics included recruitment and networking opportunities, skills assessment and training programs, the further development of the Red-White-Red Card (RWR Card) framework, and efforts to strengthen Austria's position as an attractive business location.

The presentation highlighted the IFO's focus on recruiting qualified international professionals from six key partner countries: the Philippines, Indonesia, Brazil, Albania, Kosovo, and Mexico. Emphasizing the need for innovative workforce solutions, the speakers shared the initiative's mission:

"The growing demand for skilled workers calls for new strategies. Through the International Skilled Worker Initiative (IFO), we help our members find the right skilled workers from third countries."

Through these programs, WKO and IFO continue to support Austrian businesses by connecting them with qualified talent and promoting sustainable workforce development.

Your Future Made In Austria.



Ms. Marie Cris Gambal, BScN, delivered a presentation on "More Than Just Orientation: How to Successfully Integrate International Nurses in the Long Term." She emphasized that successful integration goes far beyond initial onboarding and requires sustained, structured support throughout the entire professional journey of international nurses.

She highlighted the importance of continuous professional development, clear clinical guidance, and accessible language and communication support, as well as the role of mentorship programs in helping nurses adapt to new healthcare systems. Cultural integration was also a key focus, with an emphasis on fostering inclusive workplaces where international nurses feel respected, understood, and valued.

She further stressed that long-term retention depends not only on professional training, but also on social integration, team cohesion, and institutional commitment to diversity. By creating supportive environments and clear career pathways, healthcare institutions can ensure that international nurses successfully grow into their roles and remain a strong, stable part of Austria's healthcare workforce.



Mr. Raphael Rey Bacolod presented "From Arrival to a Sense of Belonging: ABA Support for Filipino Healthcare Professionals in Austria," highlighting the assistance available to Filipino healthcare workers as they begin their careers and lives in Austria. The presentation focused on how ABA - Work in Austria supports international professionals through guidance on relocation, integration, and settlement, helping them transition smoothly from arrival to becoming valued members of Austrian society and the healthcare workforce.



Ms. Anastacia Knoll, MLS presented on "Caring for Others - Caring for Yourself: Mental Health in the Care Sector," highlighting the critical importance of mental well-being among healthcare professionals. She emphasized that those working in caregiving roles must also prioritize their own emotional and psychological health in order to provide safe, compassionate, and sustainable care to others.

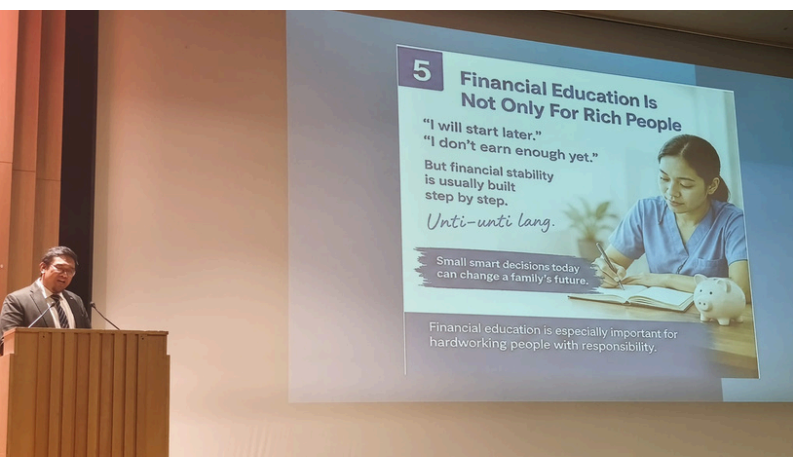
Her presentation addressed common challenges in the care sector, including stress, burnout, emotional fatigue, and workload pressure, and stressed the need for self-care strategies, peer support systems, and open communication within teams. She also underlined the responsibility of healthcare institutions to create supportive environments that encourage mental health awareness, early intervention, and access to professional support services.

Ultimately, she reinforced that protecting the mental health of caregivers is essential not only for individual well-being, but also for maintaining high-quality patient care and a resilient healthcare system.



Mr. Joseph Diaz delivered a presentation on “Finance Competence,” emphasizing the importance of financial literacy and practical money management skills in both professional and personal life. He highlighted how a strong understanding of budgeting, saving, and financial planning empowers individuals—especially international professionals—to make informed decisions, achieve stability, and avoid common financial pitfalls.

He further stressed the role of financial competence in supporting long-term integration and success in Austria, particularly for skilled workers managing relocation, contracts, taxes, and daily living costs. His talk reinforced that financial awareness is a key foundation for independence, confidence, and sustainable career development.



The information workshop served as an open forum where participants were able to raise individual concerns and receive direct responses in a supportive setting. Key topics included workplace integration, staffing challenges, communication barriers, professional expectations, and day-to-day experiences of nurses working in Austria.

Several nurses delivered personal speeches, sharing their real-life experiences in the healthcare system, including both challenges and successes in adapting to new clinical environments. Their testimonies provided valuable insight into the realities of nursing practice in Austria, especially for international healthcare professionals.

The session fostered meaningful dialogue between participants and speakers, encouraging transparency, empathy, and shared problem-solving. It also highlighted the importance of continuous support systems, professional guidance, and peer exchange in strengthening the nursing community and improving working conditions in the healthcare sector.



The event was successfully conducted with strong support from both participants and sponsors, whose active engagement contributed greatly to its overall impact and smooth execution. A central focus of the congress was the theme of mental health, which was consistently reflected across discussions and presentations, emphasizing the importance of well-being, resilience, and support within the care and professional sectors.

The congress also served as an effective platform for information dissemination, ensuring that participants received relevant updates, services, and guidance on key professional and integration topics. Beyond the formal program, the event fostered a strong sense of camaraderie, encouraging open exchange, informal networking, and meaningful connections among attendees.

It created valuable opportunities for participants to meet new people, share experiences, and build professional and personal relationships, strengthening community ties and encouraging continued collaboration beyond the event itself.



The Filipino Health Professionals, a chapter organization of the BPGÖ based in Upper Austria, commenced an oath-taking ceremony led by Candy Cypres-Bauzon, First Secretary and Consul of the Philippine Embassy. The ceremony marked a formal and meaningful moment of commitment among Filipino healthcare professionals, reinforcing unity, professional dedication, and service within the community in Austria.





SOCIALIZATION EVENT

After the National Congress day event, a lively socialization party was held in the late afternoon, creating a warm and festive conclusion to the day's formal program. The gathering featured a short entertainment segment where Filipino health workers proudly showcased their talents in singing and dancing, reflecting the strong sense of culture, unity, and creativity within the community.

A tombola was also conducted, adding excitement to the celebration as prizes were drawn and awarded to lucky participants. The program fostered a joyful atmosphere filled with laughter, interaction, and shared experiences.

Beyond entertainment, the socialization served as an important opportunity for informal networking, allowing participants to strengthen professional and personal connections in a relaxed setting. It highlighted the spirit of camaraderie among attendees and provided a meaningful space to unwind, celebrate achievements, and further build community bonds after a successful congress day.

